Northstar Services

Customer Communication, Privacy and Special Handling Standards

Email, Chat, Sensitive Requests, Vulnerable Customers, Security Concerns and Communication Controls

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1. Purpose and Scope

This document defines communication and information-handling standards for customer-facing employees. It applies across email, chat, telephone, social messaging, and assisted service channels.

The standards are intended to reduce accidental disclosure, inconsistent messaging, poor handling of sensitive situations, and unnecessary collection of customer information. They complement, rather than replace, the organization's formal privacy, security, legal, and records-retention requirements.

2. Minimum Necessary Information

Collect and access only the information necessary to perform the requested service. Before opening an account record, identify the business reason for access.

Do not copy sensitive personal information into free-text notes when the system provides a structured field. Do not record passwords, authentication codes, full payment-card details, or security answers.

When attaching screenshots or documents to a case, check for unrelated personal information. If the material is not required for the investigation, do not attach it. If sensitive information is accidentally received, follow the incident-handling procedure rather than forwarding it to additional employees.

3. Email Standards

Customer emails should identify the issue being addressed, state the action taken or required, and provide the next step. Use approved templates where they exist, but customize the factual content so that the message accurately reflects the customer's case.

Do not include sensitive account information in an email when the recipient's identity cannot be established through the approved process. Use the secure portal or verified communication channel when required.

Before sending an email, verify the recipient address and attachments. If a message is sent to the wrong recipient or contains information that should not have been disclosed, report the event immediately through the privacy or security incident workflow.

4. Chat and Messaging

Chat is a real-time channel and customers may expect immediate answers. Speed does not remove verification requirements.

Use short paragraphs, clear instructions, and explicit next steps. Avoid sending a long internal policy excerpt when a concise explanation is sufficient. If a procedure requires a secure form or portal, direct the customer to the approved destination rather than requesting sensitive data in chat.

When a chat is transferred, the receiving employee should review the transcript and case context before repeating questions.

5. Sensitive Requests

Sensitive requests include account ownership changes, requests for another person's information, payment information, access recovery, legal demands, security concerns, suspected fraud, and requests to bypass normal controls.

Do not disclose another customer's information even if the requester claims to be a colleague, family member, manager, or authorized representative unless authorization can be verified through the approved process.

If a legal representative, regulator, law-enforcement organization, or government authority contacts frontline support, follow the designated legal or compliance intake route. Do not provide records directly unless the applicable procedure authorizes the representative to do so.

6. Suspected Account Compromise

Indicators of possible account compromise include unexpected password or contact-detail changes, unusual login activity reported by the customer, unauthorized transactions, unexpected security notifications, or a customer stating that someone else has accessed the account.

Do not attempt to investigate by revealing security controls or asking for secrets. Follow the account-security workflow, which may include temporary restrictions, verified recovery, specialist review, or transaction protection.

Document the indicators and actions taken without copying authentication secrets. If the event may affect multiple customers, escalate as a potential security incident.

7. Vulnerable or Distressed Customers

Some customers may require additional care because of age, disability, language barriers, financial distress, bereavement, cognitive limitations, or other circumstances that make a normal interaction difficult. Employees should not diagnose or label customers. Instead, focus on the assistance needed.

Offer reasonable communication adjustments supported by company procedures, such as additional explanation, an alternative channel, a trusted representative process, or a supervisor review.

If a customer expresses immediate danger, self-harm, or a threat to another person, do not attempt to act as a counselor. Follow the organization's emergency or safeguarding procedure and notify the appropriate supervisor or specialist team immediately.

8. Difficult Conversations

Employees should acknowledge the customer's concern without agreeing to facts that have not been established. Useful language includes: "I understand this has been frustrating," "I can review what happened," and "Here is what I can do next."

Avoid statements such as "That's not my department," "You should have read the terms," or "There is nothing I can do." When a request cannot be fulfilled, explain the applicable limitation and the available alternative or escalation route.

If a customer uses abusive language, set a clear boundary. If the customer continues to threaten or harass the employee, follow the abusive-contact procedure. Employees are not required to remain in an interaction that presents a credible safety risk.

9. Translation and Accessibility

When language or accessibility needs affect the employee's ability to understand the customer, use approved interpretation or accessibility services where available. Do not rely on informal translation for legally significant, financial, or security-sensitive communication when an approved service is required.

Customer-facing communications should use plain language, avoid unexplained acronyms, and present important actions in a clear order. Accessibility accommodations should be recorded only to the extent necessary to provide the service.

10. Social Media and Public Channels

Customer-specific account matters must not be resolved through public social-media replies. Move the customer to an approved private channel and follow verification requirements before discussing account information.

Do not disclose internal investigations, employee information, confidential incident details, or another customer's information. If a public post alleges a serious safety, privacy, fraud, or security issue, route it through the appropriate specialist process while maintaining a neutral public response.

11. Records and Knowledge Feedback

Customer communications that affect a decision, commitment, complaint, billing action, or service request must be captured in the approved system of record.

Employees should report recurring customer questions and ambiguous policy wording to Knowledge Management. When an article is unclear, do not create a personal workaround that contradicts controlled guidance. Mark the knowledge issue for review and use the approved escalation path for urgent ambiguity.

Managers should periodically sample communications for accuracy, privacy, tone, and adherence to approved procedures. Training should focus on recurring failure patterns rather than isolated stylistic preferences.

Appendix A — Quick Decision Reference

Sensitive information received accidentally	Do not copy or forward it; follow the privacy/security incident procedure.
Wrong email recipient	Report immediately through the privacy incident route.
Suspected account compromise	Use the account-security workflow and avoid requesting authentication secrets.
Public social-media complaint	Move account-specific discussion to an approved private channel.
Language/accessibility barrier	Use approved interpretation or accessibility support when required.
Customer in immediate danger	Follow emergency/safeguarding procedure and notify the designated specialist or supervisor.